

PUNJAB ORIGIN

Makki Ki Roti

Cornmeal Flatbread

Punjab's Winter Harvest Classic

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Makki Ki Roti

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Makki Ki Roti

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Punjab's Winter Harvest, on a Plate

No dish captures a Punjabi winter quite like makki ki roti, the cornmeal flatbread eaten almost exclusively during the colder months, when maize is harvested across the region's fields. Its constant companion is sarson ka saag, a mustard greens curry, and the pairing of the two is so iconic that in Punjab, simply saying "saag" is often understood to mean the whole meal, roti included.

The dish is deeply tied to Lohri, the Punjabi harvest festival celebrated every January, which honors the winter crop and the end of the coldest part of the season. Corn flour lacks the gluten that gives wheat dough its stretch, which is why makki ki roti has always been made differently from other Indian breads — patted gently by hand between wet palms or sheets of plastic, rather than rolled with a pin, since the dough would simply crumble under a rolling pin's pressure.

It's a rustic, humble bread, often less than perfectly round, and that imperfection is part of its charm — a reminder of its farmhouse origins, made by hand in kitchens across rural Punjab for generations.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Punjab's Winter Harvest, on a Plate, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

The defining dish of the Punjabi winter season, tied closely to the maize harvest. Central to Lohri, the January harvest festival, and to Punjabi winter family meals generally. Almost always served with sarson ka saag (mustard greens curry) — the two are considered inseparable. Traditionally a farmhouse bread, valued for its rustic, imperfect shape as much as its flavor.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	10m	20m	4
ACTIVE PREP	REST TIME	COOK TIME	SERVINGS (6 ROTIS)

Med
DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Mixing bowl
- Two sheets of plastic or parchment (for patting the dough, in place of a rolling pin)
- Heavy tava or cast-iron skillet
- A wide, flat spatula for transferring the fragile rolled dough
- Basting brush or spoon for ghee

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Makki ki roti dough doesn't keep well and should be made fresh each time you plan to cook, as corn flour dries out and cracks quickly once mixed. Cooked rotis are best eaten immediately while warm and pliable — they turn firm and less pleasant to eat once fully cooled, and don't reheat particularly well.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dough

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Makki ka atta (fine cornmeal/corn flour)	2 cups	250 g	2 katori
Water, warm	¾–1 cup	180–240 ml	¾–1 katori
Salt	½ tsp	3 g	to taste
Whole wheat flour — optional, for easier binding	2 tbsp	15 g	2 tbsp
Ghee, for cooking and serving	3 tbsp	45 g	3 chammach

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Look specifically for "makki ka atta" or fine yellow cornmeal at South Asian grocers — regular American cornmeal is often coarser and will need extra care and moisture to bind well. A small addition of whole wheat flour (about 2 tablespoons per 2 cups of corn flour) is a common home-cook trick to help the dough hold together, and is not considered inauthentic. If you can't find makki atta at all, finely ground polenta flour is the closest widely available substitute.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Dough

01 MIX THE DOUGH

Combine the corn flour, salt, and whole wheat flour (if using) in a bowl. Gradually add warm water, mixing with your hands until a soft, slightly crumbly dough comes together — it won't be as smooth or elastic as a wheat dough.

02 REST BRIEFLY

Cover and let the dough rest for about 10 minutes. This gives the corn flour a chance to absorb the water fully, making it easier to handle.

Chef tip. corn flour dough should feel like soft, slightly sticky clay — if it's cracking at the edges, work in a little more warm water.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The dough is ready when it holds together in a ball without crumbling apart, even though it will still feel more delicate than a wheat dough.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Patting & Cooking

03 DIVIDE AND PAT

Divide the dough into 6 portions. Place one portion between two sheets of plastic or parchment and gently pat it into a round, about ¼ inch / 6 mm thick, using your palms rather than a rolling pin.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Patting & Cooking, continued

04 TRANSFER CAREFULLY

Peel back the top sheet, then use the bottom sheet to help flip the roti gently onto your hand or directly onto a hot tava — the dough is fragile, so handle it gently and don't worry if the edges aren't perfectly round.

05 COOK SLOWLY WITH GHEE

Cook on a medium-hot tava, patiently, for about 2 minutes per side, adding ghee around the edges as it cooks. Press gently with a spatula to help it cook through evenly.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Patting & Cooking, continued

06 FINISH AND SERVE

Cook until both sides show golden-brown spots and the roti feels set rather than doughy. Brush with extra ghee and serve immediately while warm.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Rushing the transfer from plastic sheet to tava is the most common cause of a cracked or torn roti. Move slowly and support the dough fully with your palm during the transfer.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with sarson ka saag and a generous dollop of white butter melting on top.
- Often finished with a small piece of jaggery on the side, for the classic sweet-savory Punjabi winter pairing.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served whole alongside a bowl of saag, with visible butter pooling in the center.

Family Style

- Cooked in batches and served hot straight from the tava, since makki ki roti is best eaten immediately.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Keep the dough covered with a damp cloth while you work, since corn flour dries out quickly between portions.
- A generous hand with ghee while cooking is essential — corn flour dough is naturally low in fat and needs it to stay tender.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Unlike wheat doughs, this one truly is best mixed fresh right before cooking — it doesn't rest or store well.
- Prepare your saag or curry ahead of time, so the roti is the very last thing cooked and served piping hot.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Punjabi cooks add a small amount of boiled, mashed potato to the dough, which noticeably improves binding and softness without compromising the corn flavor.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

140 kcal	3 g	22 g	5 g	2.5 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with fat used and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Stuffed Makki Roti — filled with a spiced radish or fenugreek leaf mixture, a popular home variation.

Bajra-Makki Roti — a blend of corn and pearl millet flours for a heartier, more textured bread.

Sweet Makki Roti — a rare festive version with a touch of jaggery worked into the dough itself.

Why does my dough keep cracking?

Corn flour lacks gluten, so it needs to be kept moist and handled gently — add a little more warm water and work quickly once mixed.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Is this gluten-free?

Yes, if made purely with corn flour and no added wheat flour. Many traditional versions do add a small amount of wheat flour for easier handling, so check your recipe if gluten-free is essential.

Can I make the dough smoother by kneading longer?

Not really — unlike wheat dough, corn flour dough doesn't develop elasticity with kneading, since it has no gluten to work. Gentle mixing and resting is all it needs.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Makki ka atta	fine cornmeal, the defining ingredient of this bread.
Sarson ka Saag	a mustard greens curry, the traditional and essential pairing for this roti.
Lohri	a Punjabi harvest festival celebrated every January, closely tied to this dish.
Makhan	fresh, unsalted white butter, traditionally melted over the hot roti.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Makki Ki Roti

15m	10m
ACTIVE PREP	REST TIME
20m	**4**
COOK TIME	SERVINGS (6 ROTIS)
Med	
DIFFICULTY	

DOUGH

Makki ka atta	250 g
Water	180–240 ml
Salt	3 g
Whole wheat flour — optional	15 g
Ghee	45 g

METHOD

01 **Mix the dough.** Combine the corn flour, salt, and whole wheat flour (if using) in a bowl.

02 **Rest briefly.** Cover and let the dough rest for about 10 minutes.

03 **Divide and pat.** Divide the dough into 6 portions.

04 **Transfer carefully.** Peel back the top sheet, then use the bottom sheet to help flip the roti gently onto your hand or directly onto a hot tava — the dough is fragile, so handle it gently and don't worry if the edges aren't perfectly round.

05 **Cook slowly with ghee.** Cook on a medium-hot tava, patiently, for about 2 minutes per side, adding ghee around the edges as it cooks.

06 **Finish and serve.** Cook until both sides show golden-brown spots and the roti feels set rather than doughy.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

- [ ] Makki ka atta — 250 g
- [ ] Whole wheat flour — optional — 15 g
- [ ] Salt — 3 g
- [ ] Ghee — 45 g

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